

Qualitative research results

Each interviewer has a number assigned to them:

Participant 1: Forklift company head of marketing

Participant 2: Forklift company owner

Participant 3: Real estate business owner

Key points are marked

After conducting qualitative research, I have found the following:

1. AI understanding of employees of SMEs:

All the participants we interviewed knew or were aware of what AI is and they had all used some form of AI before in their lives, the level of use being different for each participant. Participant 1 (P1) and participant 2 (P2) had used ChatGPT before and started using it recently. Participant 3 (P3) was a little more experienced, he expressed that he used to have the premium version of it but has since stopped that subscription.

P1 and P2 said that they started learning more about AI because of us meeting and talking to them at the Digiwerkplaats event and took notes of our conversation. This indicates that after having gained some understanding and insights into AI, they immediately started to have more of an interest and will to learn more about the topic. P1 said, "I met you guys and then I started asking questions. I think it's amazing, but I still have to learn a lot" (P1). P3 upon having to explain his familiarity with AI, already said he used ChatGPT frequently before and stated some benefits of AI as well as some downsides to it, which all things stated were real and possible situations. This indicates that he obviously has prior knowledge of AI, meaning he might already have a more educated and set opinion of AI.

2. Concerns about AI:

2.1. Lack of a human element

After the first question, both P1 and P2 expressed concerns regarding the lack of a human element, the lack of human emotions. P1 shared that he used GenAI to generate some text and P2 (his boss) called him out on it, saying that that is not the way that they talk to customers. "Yeah, it's not really with, I don't know, a kind of touch of a human actually," (P1). So, the missing human aspect to AI is something that bothers them. This is something that I noticed doesn't bother P3.

2.2. Data privacy

Both P1 and P2 expressed some privacy concerns. They wondered where and how their data was being stored when interacting with ChatGPT, things like their questions and responses. "If I put things in AI, like ChatGPT, where is it? Who has it?" (P2). So, where their data is stored is a concern for them. They also mentioned how AI can be used to do harm and provided an example such as using the likeness of celebrities and portraying them in

unfavorable ways. So, the privacy concern of stealing a person's likeness and identity to cause harm to them using AI is something they fear.

2.3. Fear of what AI is capable

P3 from the start held a different view to AI than the others. He is someone who is against AI and thinks that we have no need for it in our lives as it is. "Honestly, I'm not a big fan. I'm sorry. But I think with all technologies, it's all about how you use it," (P3). He says that AI only benefits the higher up people and that it's not a technology for the general population. There's a lot of money and investment opportunities involved in this new technology, which for him makes it something that money hungry people can and will exploit, which is one of the factors as to why he isn't a big fan of it. But he also recognizes both the benefits and risks that AI poses. It can be used for good but also hurt many people. He talks about conspiracy theories like AI replacing judges and keeps mentioning "the sky is the limit" (P3), which is referring to the amount of damage AI can cause, an incredible amount of it. What the data shows is that he might have the biggest concerns of AI out of anyone, having so much fear of it that he rejects AI and thinks we are completely fine without it. This is a sort of underlying fear that isn't all that apparent at first, but nonetheless a big concern.

2.4. Main source of information

Another concern P3 talks about is ChatGPT again. He has concerns over how much Generative AI is being used in the daily lives of others. He notices that people are using it to get their daily information. "If we start to see artificial intelligence as our source of information, so our main source of information, I think it's not transparent enough of how the algorithm and how the thoughts... are being put in there," (P3). While he was still using ChatGPT, he noticed that it would not listen to him a lot of the times and it would also give him wrong responses and information. He also recognizes that it was ultimately built by a human, meaning that there will always be biases involved, which is why he chose to stop using it altogether. So, he, having realized all of this, grew concerns that people would start using it as their daily source of information because of his past experiences with it.

2.5. AI in media and pop-culture

Regarding the portrayal of AI in media and pop culture, all three participants expressed how the media does indeed have an influence on how people think about AI, P1 specifically mentioning that there is a strong case of that in his home country of the Netherlands. "If I see something on TV, like, uh, the typical Dutch, uh, average person... they believe it straight away. So you see like, uh, it's dangerous," (P1). He says that people here will believe most things that they see in the news or media. That isn't the case for everything, but with statements that are more easily believable, they will believe in. So, if there is a stigma against AI in the media, they will also hold that same opinion on it. And he understands that that is a dangerous fact of the world. Therefore, making this a factor that influences people's perceptions on AI. P2 also recognizes this fact but doesn't expand on it. P3 says that the media would definitely be able to influence his view, and it may have already happened. "In the end, it's already a bit of a power thing. Because you see China, the States, and Europe... it's like a cold war," (P3). After being asked question 10, he speaks about how it depends on how it's being applied, it depends on the person using it. He goes

into how it's all a power struggle. All of the world's super powers are trying to develop the technology in faster ways than before and make use of it and get ahead of their competition, making this matter a lot bigger than we ever expected it to be. So, the data shows that the media has so much power to influence opinions, that it causes the world's powers to scramble to be the best at this technology, therefore leading him to believe that it can very easily affect his view on it too. So, it does affect people's perceptions, very much so.

3. Impact of AI on Jobs:

3.1. AI Automation

In terms of job replacement, P1 and P2 given the nature of their industry, recognize that there is much room for automation to happen and for AI to get swiftly adopted not necessarily into their roles quite yet but in the roles of the forklift operator as an example. "You can... place cameras and automate some tasks, for example, stopping the forklift when it sees a person," (P1). They say that automated forklifts are already a real thing but automated driving systems for forklifts at the moment are very limited as the warehouses they operate in are specifically created for the AI to be able to do its thing. Everything is the right measurement and it's a very controlled environment. For regular warehouses it wouldn't be possible right now as there are too many unpredictable variables that AI can't deal with. But they do realize that automation in the cases of self-driving is a real possibility and the same with fully automated warehouses that operate with zero humans, and it's something that can take up many people's jobs.

3.2. Future employee replacement

P2 also has an interesting insight into automation. He does not fear being replaced anytime soon by AI, but instead looks at it like AI will be able to replace any future employees he would need. "Maybe now it's still 30 [employees] in five years because some tasks are being overtaken by AI," (P2). Like if he currently has 30 employees, and to expand his company he would hypothetically need 5 more employees. He wants to be able to use AI and automation to replace those 5 future employees, meaning he won't have to hire any more people. And that means his current employees won't lose out on their jobs. So, he wants to use AI to expand his company, but he doesn't want to have to release any of his current employees and instead will replace any future employees he needs for his operations.

3.3. No fears over replacement

But for the most part, all three participants have no concerns about AI replacing their positions, especially P2 and P3 who both have ownership positions within their company. They all recognize possibilities of it happening whether it be in their position/industries or in that of others, but they do not feel any immediate fear of it happening to them, especially when it comes to people in higher positions of power. Meaning AI is still not at those levels.

4. Willingness and methods to learn AI:

4.1. Eagerness to learn

All three participants said that they were eager and willing to learn about AI, all giving scores between 8-9 out of 10 on their willingness to learn. "I'm very interested. On a scale from 0 to 10? I think it's an 8 or a 9," (P2). P3 specified he would only be interested in it if it could benefit his business more. The data shows that they all know that times are changing, and they want to get ahead of the curb with this new technology and they know the benefits it can bring them, making them very willing and open to learning more about it.

4.2. Learning barriers

For P1 and P2, a barrier they face to learn about AI is the lack of knowledge they have on it. They feel so overwhelmed by it all that they have no clue where to start on it and because of that it might scare them away. "There's so much, I think. I want to learn everything right away, but it's not possible. So one at a time," (P1). So, if we can introduce them to AI in a more beginner friendly way then they might be more open to trying more. Then some of them mentioned a lack of time to learn. This case is all about personal circumstances and cannot be controlled. P3 states that a barrier for him and his business would be a lack of interest not from him but for his employees. "I think lack of interest from employees is a barrier... Employees, they like to repeat things, keep things easy," (P3). So, if his employees have no desire to learn it then it would be pointless to implement it to his business right now and therefore all of his interest in the topic business wise is lost. But in the case of P1 and P2, their colleagues, which are all above 50, would also be open and interested in adopting it. This difference in opinions could all be due to personal preferences and circumstances, work environment, living environment, difference in cultures and lifestyle, etc. Since P1 and P2 are in different industries and countries than P3. It could be due to many different factors.

4.3. Learning methods

Right now, all participants are taking a more self-paced approach to learning AI. They mentioned methods of learning such as YouTube (YT) videos, that was always the first method they mentioned. "I think with YouTube videos and things like that, for now it's going great. I'm learning a lot more," (P1). Suggesting learning through YT videos is the easiest and most accessible method to learn not only AI but most other things. P2 also said he ordered a book online about AI, the author of that book being Alexander Klöpping. Meaning informative literature is something that is commonly turned to when wanting to learn. They also mentioned a way they use to learn AI is through AI itself, namely ChatGPT. They would ask questions that they want answered. So, letting people explore Generative AI as a source of learning might be a good idea since it's what they comfortably used to learn and answer their questions. They are also open to taking part in the workshops they said, for them and their company.

4.4. Allocated time to learn

All of them said they'd be willing to spend around 2-3 hours per week studying and learning about AI. "Yeah, maybe two, three hours a week, I think," (P1). They're willing to spend that

amount of time because they consider it to be worth it and believe the time, they put in will be given back to them. Meaning they see the value in learning it. "I'm willing to spend this amount of time because I think in the future, I can regain my time back," (P1).